

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1552

By Camper

A RESOLUTION to commemorate the 160th anniversary of the
Memphis Massacre of 1866.

WHEREAS, millions of Africans and their descendants were enslaved in the United States from 1619 through 1865, and the system of slavery and the racial discrimination upon which it depended became deeply embedded in the nation's social and legal structures; and

WHEREAS, although slavery was abolished by the ratification of the Thirteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution in 1865 following the Civil War, the period of Reconstruction that followed was marked by significant unrest and violence, particularly in the Southern states; and

WHEREAS, during Reconstruction, newly freed African Americans sought to exercise their rights as citizens, including the rights to work, to assemble, to worship, and to participate in civic life, often in the face of hostility and resistance; and

WHEREAS, the Memphis Massacre occurred in Memphis from May 1 to May 3, 1866, during the early Reconstruction era, constituting a tragic and significant chapter in the history of this State and the nation; and

WHEREAS, during this event, a white mob carried out a brutal and unprovoked attack on Black residents of Memphis, including formerly enslaved persons and Union veterans, resulting in the deaths of dozens of African Americans, injuries to many others, and the destruction of numerous homes, schools, and churches; and

WHEREAS, the scale and nature of the violence, including the targeting of homes, educational institutions, and places of worship, inflicted lasting harm on the Black community in Memphis and underscored the vulnerability of newly freed citizens during this period; and

WHEREAS, the violence and devastation of the Memphis Massacre drew national attention to the urgent need for legal protections for the civil rights of African Americans and contributed to the broader national dialogue that culminated in the adoption of the Fourteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution, guaranteeing equal protection under the law; and

WHEREAS, the events in Memphis were among the first large-scale acts of racial violence during Reconstruction and were followed by similar incidents elsewhere, further illustrating the challenges faced in securing civil rights and equal protection; and

WHEREAS, despite the magnitude of the violence and the extensive documentation of the events, those responsible for the Memphis Massacre were not held accountable, and acts of racial violence continued during Reconstruction and beyond; and

WHEREAS, in the years following Reconstruction, the erosion of federal protections led to the rise of segregation and disenfranchisement, reinforcing the importance of continued vigilance in the protection of civil rights; and

WHEREAS, it is important that the history of the Memphis Massacre and the broader experiences of African Americans during Reconstruction be remembered accurately and not minimized, so that future generations may better understand the challenges faced in the pursuit of justice and equality; and

WHEREAS, commemorating such events provides an opportunity for reflection, education, and a renewed commitment to the principles upon which this State and nation are founded; and

WHEREAS, reflection upon such events provides an opportunity to reaffirm a shared commitment to the principles of equal protection, justice, and opportunity for all citizens; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE

CONCURRING, that we commemorate the 160th anniversary of the Memphis Massacre of 1866, honor the memory of those who lost their lives, and recognize this event as a solemn and significant chapter in the history of Tennessee and the United States.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the members of this General Assembly commemorate this solemn occasion as an opportunity for reflection, greater civic awareness, and a continued commitment to a more just and unified society grounded in equality and respect for the dignity of all persons.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.